Brandon Jahoor

Robotics Software Engineering for Humanoid Embodiment of Physical AI

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University of Waterloo | *Candidate for BASc in Mechatronics Engineering Honours, Minor in Artificial Intelligence* *2028*

Skills

Robot Learning: VLAs ($\pi_{0.5}$, GR00T, SmolVLA), ACT, RL, imitation learning, cross-embodiment, sim-to-real, synthetic data
Sim & Robotics: Isaac Sim/Lab, MuJoCo, Genesis, cuRobo, ROS2, WBC, URDF/USD, IK/FK
Software & Infra: Python, C++, PyTorch, JAX, openpi, LeRobot, Docker, Linux, sharded training, Nvidia Jetson, Claude Code

Experience

Robotics Software Engineering (Co-op) Sept 2026 – April 2027
Axibo AI | *Humanoids* | *site* · *portfolio* *Ontario*

- Fine-tune, evaluate and deploy SOTA VLAs (**$\pi_{0.5}$**, **GR00T N1.7**, **DM0.5**) end-to-end as generalizable bimanual and whole-body policies, both integrated with the **WBC** and locomotion policies, with a focus on cross-embodiment and sim-to-real.
- Created and designed a batched synthetic data generation toolchain for delta-EE bimanual policies using **Genesis World**, **Isaac**, **MuJoCo** and **cuRobo** (motion planning). Features like augmentation, domain-randomization, noise improve **cross-embodiment**.
- Accelerated SOTA VLA research iteration and cut compute cost with custom training pipelines and scripts forked from SOTA repos, primarily **openpi** (**JAX/Orbax**) (**2.5**× faster steps) and **Isaac-GR00T** (**PyTorch**), without sacrificing benchmarks.
- Optimized VLA training through sharding across multi-datacenter GPUs, upgraded version pins, selective weight and optimizer-state quantization, partial backbone freezing/pruning, selective rematerialization and batched checkpointing.
- Built batched sim evaluation toolchains with custom success criteria (per-component scoring with penalties) for SOTA bimanual & whole-body policies, ran **sim-to-sim** & **sim-to-real** evaluation on a variety of humanoids & bimanual arms, and raised benchmark scores by tuning training recipes & inference settings.
- Optimizing real-time inference via **RTC** & Mixture of Horizons (**MoH**), tuning denoising steps & prediction horizons.
- Productionizing the custom **UMI** pipeline and developed training recipes to maximize the efficacy of public data and synthetically generated data (including re-simulating public datasets with custom modifications) while minimizing required real-world data.
- Architected robotic runtimes with **LLM/agent-harness** orchestration, either sequencing VLA skills or driving the whole robot directly. Built toolchains, pipelines and workflows across the stack using **agent-centric** development.

Robotics Software Engineering (Co-op) Jan 2026 – April 2026
Thalassa Robotics | *Subsea Robotics* | *site* · *portfolio* *California*

- Built a high-fidelity toolchain on **Isaac Sim** used team-wide, integrating and configuring **optics and hydrodynamics** it lacks.
- Prepared the robot's **USD** model and joint articulation so the simulated assembly matched the real one.
- Layered control abstractions so simulated motors drive exactly like the real servos, with acceleration-bounded interpolation.

Robotics Software Engineering (Research Assistant) Sept 2025 – Dec 2025
University of Waterloo RoboHub | *Robotics Research Lab* | *gitlab* · *site* · *portfolio* *Ontario*

- Streamed **human arm motion** from **Xsens MOCAP** into **ROS2** in real time, for retargeting onto a 7-axis **Franka Emika Panda**.
- Containerised the **ROS2** stack in **Docker** so results reproduced across the lab's workstations.

Robotics Engineering (Co-op) June 2025 – Aug 2025
University of Waterloo Robotics Team | *Mars Rover Team* | *github* · *site* · *portfolio* *Ontario*

- Developed a **ROS2 RealSense RGB-D** pipeline and solved **Mars rover drivetrain kinematics** on an **Nvidia Jetson**.

Robotics Engineering (Co-op) May 2025 – June 2025
BHF Robotics | *Agricultural Robotics* | *site* · *portfolio* *Ontario*

- Implemented **ROS2 autodrive** and trained a **deep-learning** weed/crop detector for an autonomous farming robot.

Projects

VLA Finetuning | *SmolVLA, LeRobot, SO-ARM101, Nvidia Jetson* | github · portfolio

- Trained **ACT** and **SmolVLA** on 50–100 teleoperated demos/task, running **30 Hz** on a Jetson Orin Nano.
- Optimized batch and worker counts for **LeRobot PyTorch** training on an **RTX 3060 Ti**.

Chess Robot | *SO-ARM101, SolidWorks, 3D printing, LeRobot, Placo, Python* | *Stealth Startup* | portfolio

- **CAD**-modified an **SO-ARM101** and built its rig, then developed a three-call Python API that plugs straight into a chess engine.
- Extended reach and fused the wrist to drop a motor, updating the **URDF** model, solver constraints and **LeRobot** driver.
- Built the motion engine over **LeRobot** and **Placo** IK: convergence loops, **1 mm** waypoints, **PID gravity compensation**.

Autonomous Navigation Stack | *ROS2, C++, LiDAR, A*, Foxglove* | *WATonomous* | github · portfolio
Robot Arm Simulation | *Isaac Sim, Isaac Lab, CUDA, RL* | *Stealth Startup* | portfolio
Hexapod Robot | *Nvidia Jetson, OWL-ViT, SO-ARM101, RealSense* | portfolio
AI Roommate | *Nvidia Jetson, Qwen2.5-0.5B, YOLOv8s, FastAPI* | github · portfolio
Autonomous Rover Simulation | *Gazebo, ROS2, Nav2, Python* | *RoboHub* | github · portfolio
AI Object Detection | *ROS2, OWL-ViT, RealSense, OpenCV, Python* | github · portfolio

See my portfolio: bjahoor.github.io